considered undesirable to prosecute these men in the ordinary way'. [15] This gave the governor-general in council the right to deport Indians to a place in India or outside on the grounds that they endangered 'peace'. The deportations to Mandalay, we learn from James Ker, 'had an immediate effect in calming the agitation for a time, not only in the Punjab but all over India'. [16] Two decades later, this power would be used against Bhagat Singh, not to deport him but to sentence him to be hanged at the gallows.

The die had been cast. The Punjab revolt of 1907, though much neglected by Indian historians of Independence, continued in its opposition to British rule right through to 1947, when freedom arrived. With such a background, it is not hard to resist the conclusion that Bhagat Singh's destiny was already being engraved in stone by his elders even as he was growing up.

But it was not just one uncle in the family who would so brazenly take on the British. All three sons of Arjan Singh and Jai Kaur——Kishan Singh, Ajit Singh and Swaran Singh—were members of the Ghadar Party, a fact barely recalled these days in relation to the story of Bhagat Singh. The Ghadar Party was a multi-ethnic revolutionary party founded by Indians in 1913 in San Francisco. Its leaders came from Sikh, Hindu and Muslim religions. Although it is much forgotten these days by Indians, it is the real precursor of the modern-day Congress Party, with its emphasis on secularism and cosmopolitanism. One of its main leaders, Kartar Singh Sarabha, was a student at the University of California in Berkeley. He had a great influence on Kishan Singh, who is reputed to have donated Rs. 1,000 to Kartar Singh Sarabha. Kishan Singh himself, described as a 'Jat of Jullunder and Lahore' by James Ker, 'took an active part in the disturbances in Lahore in 1907' and was as a result 'sentenced to 2-years imprisonment in the Lahore riot case'. [17] But this was not all because when later 'the peace of the Province was again disturbed in 1909 by the issue from Lahore of a flood of seditious literature', he was one of those, who was held responsible according to James Ker. [18] In March 1910, Kishan Singh was convicted 'in respect of seven pamphlets which' he was 'proved to have published or sold' and was sentenced to ten months' imprisonment. [19]